ERA 9

The Road to Secession

1857 – 1861

Dred Scott · John Brown · the Election of 1860 · secession

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did the events of 1857–1861 make civil war unavoidable?

KEY TERMS

Dred Scott · John Brown · the Election of 1860 · secession · Fort Sumter

ALIGNED TO

CED Topics 5.6–5.7 · AMSCO Ch. 5.6–5.7

SECTION

The Road to Disunion

The Dred Scott Decision, 1857



- **Dred Scott**, an enslaved man, sued for his freedom.
- Chief Justice **Roger Taney** ruled that Black Americans were not citizens.
- The Court declared Scott property—and said Congress could not ban slavery anywhere.

Dred Scott's Bombshell

CLAIM

Scott Sues

An enslaved man sues after living on free soil.

→

RULING

Taney's Court

Black people aren't citizens; Scott is property.

→

BLOW

Congress Powerless

Congress cannot ban slavery in ANY territory.

→

RESULT

North Enraged

The Missouri Compromise is void—slavery could spread everywhere.

John Brown's Raid, 1859

- Abolitionist **John Brown** seized the arsenal at **Harpers Ferry**.
- He hoped to arm enslaved people for a mass uprising.
- Captured and hanged, he became a **martyr** in the North—and a terror to the South.



SECTION

The Election of 1860

Lincoln vs. Douglas



- In 1858, **Abraham Lincoln** debated **Stephen Douglas** for an Illinois Senate seat.
- Lincoln argued forcefully against the expansion of slavery.
- He lost the race—but gained a national following.

A Four-Way Race for President

A divided Democratic Party opened the door for Lincoln

CANDIDATE	PARTY	POSITION ON SLAVERY
Abraham Lincoln	Republican	No expansion into the territories
Stephen Douglas	Northern Democrat	Let settlers decide (**popular sovereignty**)
John Breckinridge	Southern Democrat	Protect slavery everywhere
John Bell	**Constitutional Union**	Dodge the issue—save the Union

Lincoln Wins

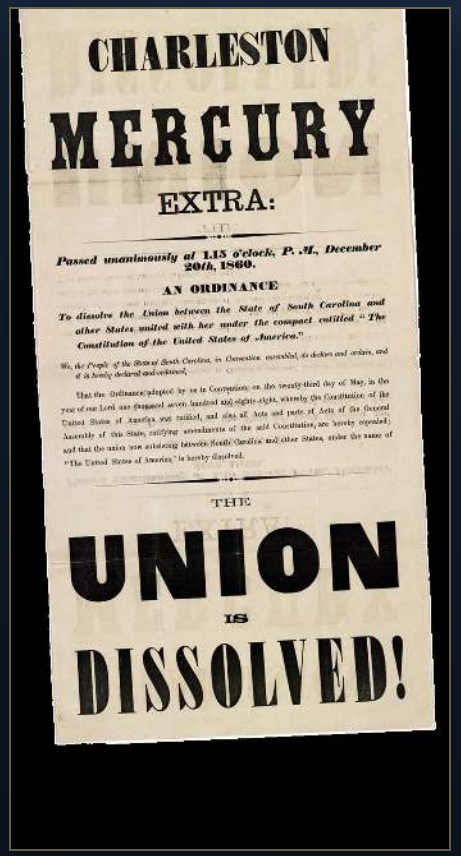
- **Lincoln** won with just 40% of the popular vote.
- He swept the populous free states of the North.
- He wasn't even on the ballot in most of the South.



SECTION

Secession & War

The Union Dissolves



CHARLESTON

MERCURY

EXTRA:

Passed unanimously at 1.15 o'clock, P. M., December 20th, 1860.

AN ORDINANCE

To dissolve the Union between the State of South Carolina and other States united with her under the compact entitled "The Constitution of the United States of America."

We, the People of the State of South Carolina, in Convention assembled, do declare and ordain, and it is hereby declared and ordained,

That the Ordinance adopted by us in Convention, on the twenty-third day of May, in the year of our Lord one thousand seven hundred and eighty-eight, whereby the Constitution of the United States of America was ratified, and also all Acts and parts of Acts of the General Assembly of this State, ratifying amendments of the said Constitution, are hereby repealed; and that the union now subsisting between South Carolina and other States, under the name of "The United States of America," is hereby dissolved.

THE

UNION

IS

DISSOLVED!

- Days after the election, **South Carolina** seceded.
- Six more Deep South states quickly followed.
- In February 1861 they formed the **Confederacy** under **Jefferson Davis**.

Fort Sumter, April 1861

- Lincoln refused to surrender **Fort Sumter** in Charleston Harbor.
- Confederate guns bombarded it into surrender.
- The **Civil War** had begun—and four more states joined the **Confederacy**.



KEY TAKEAWAYS

The Road to Secession

1. The **Dred Scott** decision and **John Brown's raid** made compromise nearly impossible.
2. **Lincoln's** victory in the four-way **Election of 1860**—with no Southern support—convinced the South it had no future in the Union.
3. **Secession** and the firing on **Fort Sumter** began the Civil War.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The Road to Secession

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how the **Dred Scott** decision pushed the North and South further apart.

CONTEXTUALIZATION

Why did **Lincoln's election**—with zero Southern electoral votes—trigger immediate secession?

ARGUMENTATION

Was civil war **inevitable** by 1860? Make and defend a claim using today's evidence.

Up next — **Lesson 23: The Civil War Begins** (Fort Sumter, strategies & early battles)